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Léa

June 1944

It was the last week of June, and Léa and Josef waited on the platform under a blindingly white sky. Two soldiers stood nearby, as always, in case any of the women tried to escape while leaving the train.

The stationmaster held up a red flag as the train approached.

“It looks like a cargo transport,” Léa said, shaking her head. “The women have always arrived by passenger train. I don’t understand.”

“They must be prioritizing passenger trains for the troops,” Josef said, glancing at the manifest. “Twenty women are listed—ten in each of the last two wagons. You take the first one, and I’ll check the second.”

Léa took a deep breath, fearing the worst. She would need to quickly prioritize which women to treat first, based on the severity of their conditions. With Olga, a Russian worker they’d brought to translate, she and Josef followed the stationmaster, flanked by the soldiers, to the end of the platform. He lifted the metal bar off the brackets on the penultimate wagon’s door—no windows, only a thin opening running along the top. He turned the latch and slid the wooden door open.

Léa gasped, burying her nose in her elbow to mask the stench. A few women groaned. Others stared silently. Their sunken eyes and jutting cheekbones showed how thin they were. She stepped forward, avoiding the waste bucket near the door. Darkness filled the wagon with despair. Frustration and anger surged in her—how could these women be transported like animals? But Josef’s words came back to her: he’d warned that after the successful Allied landings in Normandy at the month’s start and Soviet victories in the East, the Wehrmacht knew they couldn’t win